Referee-style feedback from the brown bag

"Rooms With a View," presented by Lena Marchetti, Applied Micro Lunch, Wednesday 15 July 2026, 12:10–1:15pm. About 22 attendees (faculty and grad students). Compiled by Tomás from 9 written comment cards plus my own notes of the Q&A. Attendees are identified by initials only.

What was presented. Design (housing lottery), co-swipe network and EC, first stage (EC Yr 1: 0.066 with controls), internships (+2.0 pp), earnings (+$2,080, "suggestive"), heterogeneity by first-gen and race (quick version from Hana, run the night before), and the policy pitch for SES-balanced housing.

Major comments

1. **Stratification (A.P., also M.T.).** "Your randomization is within area-by-honors blocks, but your regression only has cohort FE. Students who choose suites are richer. Some of your variation is selection." Lena said block FE are "coming in the next two weeks." A.P. also asked that the randomization-inference exercise, if we do one, permute within blocks.

2. **Is the first stage mechanical? (J.W.)** "A co-swipe within two minutes at the dining commons is not a friendship. If a third of your ties are floor-mates, more high-SES floor-mates mechanically means more high-SES ties." J.W. suggested: (a) drop dining-commons swipes entirely; (b) use a measure that is not about co-location, such as the survey nominations; (c) test whether low-SES students form ties with high-SES students *off* their floor.

3. **Earnings sample (R.K.).** R.K. asked when UI consent is collected. *Lena answered in the Q&A that consent is collected at New Student Orientation, before housing assignment.* R.K.: "Great, then at least selection into the earnings sample is pre-treatment. But the in-state restriction still worries me, because the best outcomes may leave the state."

4. **Magnitudes (S.D.).** "Your implied IV, earnings divided by first stage, is about 0.77 log points per unit of EC. Chetty et al. find a 0.5 EC gap across counties associated with about 8 percentiles of income, over an entire childhood. You're claiming a first-year floor does more than growing up in a better county. Either your EC is on a different scale or something else is going on."

5. **Multiple outcomes (S.D., L.B.).** "How many outcomes did you look at? Slide 9 showed four; the appendix slide listed a dozen or so. Which were chosen in advance?" Suggested a pre-specified index plus Romano–Wolf adjustments.

6. **Mechanism (L.B.).** "Even if EC moves, the floor could affect you through information at floor meetings, RA programming, norms. None of that needs a friendship. Don't call it a friendship effect unless you can separate it." Suggested using within-floor room distance (neighbors vs. far end of the hall) as extra variation.

7. **Policy and spillovers (L.B., M.T.).** "What happens to the high-SES students? Carrell, Sacerdote & West (2013) is the cautionary tale: they engineered peer groups and it backfired." Also: "One flagship is one flagship."

Minor comments

- (M.T.) Who counts as high-SES? "A mean high-SES share of about 70% seems very high for a public flagship. Are middle-income students in there?"
- (A.P.) Network attrition: 12.8% of Pell students vs. about 6% of others have no network data. Show treatment effects on attrition and bound.
- (J.W.) Cite Social Capital II (Chetty et al. 2022b) on exposure vs. friending bias. Your design is about exposure; say so.
- (anonymous card) Michelman, Price & Zimmerman (2022) find no gains for public-school students. How do you reconcile?
- (S.D.) Heterogeneity: the first-gen vs. continuing-gen difference looked large on the slide, but were the differences significant? Please report the test.
- (grad student, card) "Would love to see the network visualized, since it's a unique dataset!"

Positive comments

- Clean natural experiment; the housing lottery is "the right design for this question" (A.P.).
- The linkage of swipe data to aid and UI records is unusual and valuable (several cards).
- Important question with an obvious audience in higher-ed policy (L.B.).

Follow-up. No owners were assigned after the talk. Lena said she'd "circulate a response plan."